Prologue

The 2018 Elections and the illusion of a 'Naya Pakistan'

On 25 July 2018, amidst terrorist attacks and extraordinary levels of national security, Pakistan went to the polls. The 2018 election campaign had been marred by widespread allegations of military interference and marked by terror attacks, the worst of which, in Mastung in Balochistan, killed 151 people. On the Sunday before the election, the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI)'s Ikramullah Gandapur became the fourth candidate to die when he was killed in a suicide attack. Given the violence in the run-up to the elections, around 400,000 soldiers were stationed inside and outside the country's 89,500 polling stations, a fivefold increase from 2013.

Elections were being held for both the national and the provincial assemblies, with 272 seats up for grabs in Islamabad; sixty of these were reserved for women and ten for minorities. There were nearly 106 million registered voters, 23 per cent more than in the 2013 elections (EUEOM 2018). In total, 95 of the 121 registered parties took part in these elections (EUEOM 2018), but the main battle was between the PML(N) and the PTI to bring about what was only the second civilian transfer of power in Pakistan's 70-year history. Added to this mix was the problematic presence of 'extremist parties' such as the Tehreek-e-Labbaik Pakistan (TLP), the Allah-o-Akbar Tehreek (AAT) and the Pakistan Rah-e-Haq Party (PRHP) which were affiliated 'either to terrorist groups, or individuals linked to organisations that have used, incited or advocated violence' (EUEOM 2018, p. 11).

An all-out win required 137 seats and Imran Khan's PTI won 112, leaving the Pakistan Muslim League (N) (PML(N)) with only 64 and the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) with 43 seats. Even in the Punjab Assembly, the PML(N)'s heartland, PTI won 123 out of 297 seats, just 2 short of the PML(N)'s 129 seats.

While PTI's victory can be perceived to have displaced the power of the two prominent political parties, the PML(N) and the PPP, heralding a 'naya Pakistan'[1], the events leading up to the elections, and the electoral process itself, reflect